

ACADEMY BEYOND THIS WORLD

LIGHTING & RENDERING GUIDE

Graphic Production Bible 6.3 — Visual Consistency · Emotional Impact · Technical Precision

1. Core Lighting Philosophy

Light shapes emotion, guides focus, defines time, and reveals truth. Every scene tells a story with light. — LUMI

Lighting in ABTW is never accidental. Every light source must be motivated, every shadow must serve the story, and every colour temperature must support the emotional truth of the scene.

Six Core Rendering Pillars:

- Atmosphere First — mood and tone before technical detail
- Real Materials — textures behave as they would in reality
- Subtle Magic — magic enhances, never overwhelms
- Depth & Scale — layered space creates immersion
- Colour Harmony — palette serves emotion, not decoration
- Story Through Light — every light choice is a narrative choice

Consistency is Immersion. Immersion is Emotion. Emotion is Story.

2. Lighting Purpose & Function

Every light in every scene must serve at least one of these six purposes:

Purpose	Description	Visual Method
Establish Time & Mood	Tell the viewer when and how the scene feels	Colour temperature + intensity
Guide the Eye	Direct attention to what matters	Key light placement + contrast
Support Story & Theme	Reinforce the narrative moment	Warm for heart, cool for mind
Reveal or Hide Information	Control what the viewer sees	Shadow placement + fill ratio
Create Depth & Atmosphere	Build three-dimensional space	Volumetric light + fog layers
Build Emotional Connection	Make the viewer feel something	Soft vs hard light quality

3. Lighting Temperature Guide

Colour temperature is the primary emotional tool in ABTW. Every scene's temperature must be intentional.

Temperature Range	Kelvin	Emotional Qualities	Best Used For
Warm	2200K–3800K	Comforting, nostalgic, energetic, intimate, inviting	Libraries, dorms, evenings, personal moments, celebrations
Neutral	3800K–4800K	Balanced, natural, clear, realistic, adaptable	Daytime scenes, transitions, team moments, discoveries
Cool	5000K–12000K	Calm, mysterious, distant, technological, isolating	Observatory at night, research labs, anomaly events, solitude

When in doubt: warm for heart, cool for mind, mixed for balance.

4. Light Quality Guide

Quality Type	Visual Character	Shadow Quality	Emotional Effect	Best Used For
Hard	Sharp, directional, high contrast	Sharp, defined edges	Dramatic, intense, revealing	Truth moments, confrontation, focus
Soft	Gentle, diffused, flattering	Smooth, gradual edges	Dreamy, safe, intimate	Personal scenes, dormitories, memory
Diffused	Even spread, low contrast	Minimal, soft	Calm, balanced, neutral	Study spaces, daytime corridors
Rim/Edge	Highlights edges only	Separates from background	Mysterious, defined, powerful	Character reveals, anomaly moments
Volumetric	Visible light rays, dust, fog	Complex, atmospheric	Magical, vast, sacred	Grand spaces, activation moments

5. Lighting Intensity Scale

Level	Name	Description	Narrative Use
1	Whisper	Very subtle, barely there, ambient only	Background, sleeping scenes, deep night
2	Soft	Gentle, present but not dominant	Intimate moments, dormitories, reflection
3	Moderate	Clear, readable, balanced	Standard scenes, corridors, classrooms
4	Strong	Prominent, directional, impactful	Important moments, discoveries, meetings
5	Intense	Dramatic, high impact,	Activation, anomalies,

		commanding	climactic scenes
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6. Three Lighting Profiles

All scenes in ABTW fall into one of three lighting profiles, or a combination thereof.

6.1 Warm Profile — Comfort & Humanity

Mood & Emotion: Comforting, Safe, Nostalgic, Energetic, Intimate

Best Used For: Libraries/Archives, Dorms/Common Rooms, Evenings, Personal moments, Celebrations

Colour Palette: Golden yellow, amber, burnt orange, muted red-brown, dusty rose

Lighting Techniques:

- Golden key light — warm, directional, from practical sources
- Practical fire & candles — motivated warm sources
- Soft fill ambient — gentle, wrapping light
- Rim with warm edge — separates character with warmth
- Volumetric dust rays — visible light beams through windows

Example Locations: Library/Archive (Evening), Common Room (Night), Dorm Room (Personal), Dining Hall (Celebration)

6.2 Cool Profile — Mystery & Distance

Mood & Emotion: Calm, Mysterious, Intellectual, Distant, Serene

Best Used For: Observatory (Night), Research Labs, Night Exteriors, Anomaly events, Solitude/Reflection

Colour Palette: Deep navy, slate blue, medium blue, muted teal, pale lavender-white

Lighting Techniques:

- Moonlight key — cool, directional, from above
- Cool ambient fill — blue-tinted environmental light
- Rim with blue edge — cool separation light
- Practical cool lights — motivated cool sources (screens, instruments)
- Volumetric fog/haze — cool atmospheric depth

Example Locations: Observatory (Night), East Corridor (Night), Research Lab (Late Night), Rooftop (Moonlit)

6.3 Mixed Profile — Balance & Complexity

Mood & Emotion: Balanced, Dynamic, Hopeful, Curious, Epic

Best Used For: Daytime scenes, Transitions, Team moments, Important discoveries, Story climaxes

Colour Palette: Sandy beige, warm tan, muted teal-green, soft lavender, dusty purple

Lighting Techniques:

- Dual source key — warm and cool competing sources
- Balanced fill — neutral ambient
- Contrasting rims — warm on one side, cool on other
- Practical integration — motivated sources from both temperatures
- Volumetric layering — multiple atmospheric depths

Example Locations: East Corridor (Day), Academy Courtyard (Afternoon), Team Briefing (Strategy), Discovery Scene (Revelation)

6.4 Profile Combination Formulas

Combination	Result	Emotional Quality
Warm + Cool	Balanced	Warm key, cool fill — dynamic tension
Warm + Warm	Rich & Golden	Emotional, nostalgic, deeply human
Cool + Cool	Cold & Isolated	Mysterious, tense, intellectual distance

7. Time of Day Lighting Guide

Time	Key Light	Fill Light	Rim Light	Colour Temp	Emotional Quality
Dawn	Warm + soft, low angle	Soft ambient	Rose/gold edge	2800K–3200K	Hopeful, new beginning
Day	Neutral + clear, overhead	Bright ambient	Neutral edge	4000K–5000K	Energetic, clear, open
Dusk	Warm + fading, low angle	Warm ambient	Deep amber edge	2500K–3000K	Reflective, transitional
Night	Cool + contrasty, moonlight	Deep blue ambient	Silver/blue edge	5500K–7000K	Mysterious, intimate
Late Night	Deep cool, minimal	Near-black ambient	Pale blue edge	7000K+	Isolated, profound

8. Anomaly & Magic Lighting

Anomalies affect light in unusual ways. They are not glitches — they are invitations. Wild, cosmic, and full of possibility.

Anomaly Light Behaviours:

- Flicker — light stutters, rhythm breaks
- Colour shift — temperature changes without source change
- Shadow distortion — shadows move independently or lag
- Emotional reaction — light responds to character emotion
- Rule breaking — light defies physical laws intentionally

Anomaly Intensity	Visual Character	Light Behaviour	Use Case
Subtle	Small particles, faint glows, barely visible	Slight flicker, minor colour shift	First perception moments, background anomalies
Moderate	Visible energy ribbons, active symbols	Clear colour shift, shadow delay	Active investigation, symbol revelation
Intense	Strong light, fully active	Major distortion, emotional	Activation moments, trio

	symbols, dramatic	response	alignment
Overload (AVOID)	Overly busy, bright, conflicts with tone	Random, unmotivated, chaotic	NEVER USE — breaks immersion and readability

Anomalies are not glitches. They are invitations. They are wild, cosmic, and full of possibility.

9. Narrative Lighting Principles

Five types of light used narratively in ABTW:

Light Type	Character	Narrative Function	Example
Natural Light	Warm, directional, truthful	Grounds the scene in reality	Morning classroom, garden scenes
Magical Light	Glowes with meaning, responds to story	Signals hidden system activity	Symbol activation, anomaly moments
Ambient Light	Soft, immersive, balanced	Creates atmosphere and safety	Common rooms, dormitories
Contrast Light	High contrast, depth reveals importance	Directs attention, reveals truth	Discovery moments, confrontations
Focus Light	Guides attention, reveals truth	Isolates what matters most	Character close-ups, key objects

10. Official Colour Palette & Hex Codes

The official ABTW colour palette — all creative work must reference these values:

Colour Name	Hex Code	Role	Emotional Association
Deep Navy	#0B132B	Primary background, deep shadow	Depth, mystery, the unknown
Academy Blue	#182A49	Secondary background, architecture	Knowledge, stability, trust
Twilight Violet	#483F72	Transition colour, magic zones	Mystery, perception, between states
Starlight Purple	#7A5CFF	Accent, anomaly, activation	Magic, energy, revelation
Warm Gold	#E2D7B5	Primary accent, light, warmth	Guidance, truth, wisdom
Soft Sand	#D4C5A0	Secondary warm accent	Comfort, humanity, belonging
Stone Gray	#2B2F36	Neutral, architecture, shadow	Balance, structure, grounding

Symbolic Colour Values:

- Blues and violets — mystery and the unknown
- Golds and ambers — guidance and truth
- Teals and mints — technology and logic
- Purples and magentas — magic and energy
- Neutrals — balance and structure

11. Material & Texture Library

Material	Visual Character	Narrative Role	Rendering Notes
Stone	Solid, ancient, cracked, weathered	Foundation, permanence, history	Show wear and age — never pristine
Marble	Polished, reflective, veined	Ceremony, importance, knowledge	Reflections carry symbolic meaning
Wood	Warm, natural, grain visible	Humanity, comfort, organic life	Warm tones, visible grain, aged
Brass/Gold	Polished or worn, warm metallic	Sacred, meaningful, durable	Patina shows history and use
Paper	Aged, stained, textured	Knowledge, personal history, memory	Yellowed edges, ink stains, wear
Glass/Crystal	Clear, refractive, magical	Clarity, magic, conduit for light	Refractions carry colour and meaning
Fabric	Velvet, soft, with movement	Comfort, humanity, personal identity	Deep colours, visible texture, drape

12. Detail Level Guide

Shot Type	Detail Level	Focus	What to Show
Wide Shot	Compositional	Overall atmosphere and space	Architecture, light quality, mood, scale
Medium Shot	Moderate	Character in environment	Key props, lighting on character, space relationship
Close Shot	High	Specific detail and expression	Texture, material quality, symbol detail
Macro Detail	Maximum	Single element in full detail	Scratches, runic lines, tiny elements, surface truth

13. Style Do's & Don'ts

DO:

- ✓ Use warm and cool balance — tension between temperatures creates depth
- ✓ Show imperfections — wear, age, and use tell stories
- ✓ Let light guide the eye — composition through illumination
- ✓ Keep magic elegant — subtle is more powerful than overwhelming
- ✓ Respect scale — light behaves differently in grand vs intimate spaces
- ✓ Support the story — every light choice must serve the narrative
- ✓ Use motivated sources — every light must have a visible or implied source
- ✓ Layer light sources — key + fill + rim + ambient creates depth
- ✓ Use colour temperature intentionally — warm for heart, cool for mind

DON'T:

- ✗ Over-saturate — rich colours, not garish ones
- ✗ Use flat lighting — depth and contrast are essential
- ✗ Ignore atmosphere — every scene needs environmental light
- ✗ Overuse effects — magic should enhance, not dominate
- ✗ Break consistency without reason — changes must be motivated
- ✗ Distract from emotion — technical brilliance serves story, not itself
- ✗ Make scenes look random — every element has purpose
- ✗ Use pure black — use deep navy (#0B132B) or deep purple instead
- ✗ Overlight every scene — darkness and shadow are storytelling tools

14. Quality Checklist

Before finalising any illustration or render, verify:

- Lighting direction is consistent throughout the scene
- Colour temperature supports the emotional intent
- Materials behave correctly for their type
- Magic effects interact with surfaces (not floating above them)
- Depth is established through atmospheric perspective
- Focus is clear — the eye knows where to look
- Story is supported — the image tells the right emotional truth
- Anomaly effects (if present) are motivated and at correct intensity
- No pure black — deep navy or purple used for darkest values
- Symbols (if present) are integrated into the environment, not floating

Every light. Every texture. Every shadow. Every detail tells the truth.

LIGHT SHOWS THE WAY. SHADOWS HOLD THE SECRETS. TOGETHER, THEY TELL THE STORY. — LUMI